



MEASUREMENT FOUNDATIONS

Google Analytics Setup Checklist

A practical review of your GA4 setup, from the data stream and Google tag through events, key events, testing, and reporting.

CHECKLIST

Google Analytics can be installed quickly. That does not mean it has been set up well. A working tag, clean event design, and useful reporting are three different things. This checklist is meant to help you inspect the setup you have, spot gaps, and document what still needs attention.

Use it as a pre-launch checklist, a cleanup exercise, or a periodic measurement review. Check the box only when you have actually verified the item.

Current terminology note: Google Analytics now uses key events for important business actions measured in Analytics. A conversion is the corresponding concept used when important actions are used for ad-campaign measurement and optimization.

1. Property and data stream foundation

- [] The correct Google Analytics 4 property is being used for the business, site, or app under review.
- [] A Web data stream exists for the intended website and the stream URL matches the production site.
- [] The measurement ID has been verified in Admin -> Data collection and modification -> Data streams -> Web.
- [] The property time zone matches the reporting needs of the business and is not an accidental default.
- [] The property currency is appropriate for how revenue and value will be reported.
- [] The organization has documented who owns the property and who has Editor-level responsibility for configuration.

2. Google tag and implementation

- [] One intentional Google tag implementation is in place; duplicate implementations have been ruled out.
- [] The Google tag or Google Analytics tag is deployed through the intended method, such as Google Tag Manager or the site's native integration.
- [] The implementation is present on the production pages that should collect data.
- [] The measurement ID in the implementation matches the intended web data stream.
- [] Consent behavior has been reviewed for the jurisdictions and tools the business uses.
- [] Cross-domain measurement is configured where a customer journey genuinely moves across domains.
- [] Unwanted referral sources have been reviewed when third-party payment, booking, or authentication services create self-referral noise.

A common mistake is to prove that a tag fires and stop there. A better check is to prove that it fires once, in the right property, on the right pages, with the right identifiers and parameters.

3. Event design

- [] The measurement plan starts with business questions rather than a list of every interaction that could be tracked.
- [] Recommended GA4 events are used when they match the interaction and their prescribed parameters are implemented where practical.
- [] Custom events have clear names, a written purpose, and a documented trigger condition.
- [] Event names follow GA4 naming rules and are kept at 40 characters or fewer.

- [] Parameters add useful context instead of repeating information already present in the event name.
- [] For each important event, the team can explain what action caused it, what page or component generated it, and what the event is meant to answer.

4. Key events and business outcomes

- [] Only actions that matter to the success of the business are marked as key events.
- [] The team has documented why each key event matters instead of marking every tracked interaction.
- [] Lead, purchase, signup, booking, or other meaningful actions are distinguished from lower-intent engagement events.
- [] When a key event has monetary value, the implementation uses the value and currency parameters appropriately.
- [] The team understands that an event can be collected without being a key event.
- [] When Google Ads is involved, Analytics key events and Google Ads conversion actions are mapped intentionally rather than assuming they are identical settings.

5. Ecommerce and item data

For an ecommerce site, product and purchase data should be treated as a data model, not just a few button clicks.

- [] The site uses GA4 ecommerce events that match the actual shopping journey, such as viewing an item, adding to cart, beginning checkout, and purchase.
- [] Item data includes the identifiers and product context needed for analysis.
- [] Transaction values, currency, tax, shipping, and item values are mapped consistently where applicable.
- [] Duplicate purchase events have been ruled out, especially after payment redirects, refreshes, or app/plugin changes.

6. Testing before trusting the data

- [] A test visit has been completed on the production site.
- [] Realtime reporting shows the visit and expected page activity.
- [] DebugView or the chosen debugging method has been used to inspect event names and parameters during testing.
- [] Form submissions, file downloads, outbound clicks, purchases, and other key interactions have been tested where applicable.
- [] Events that should not fire have been tested as negative cases as well.
- [] A second test environment or browser profile was used when needed to rule out cached tags or stale configuration.

7. Reporting and measurement QA

- [] The business has a short written measurement plan linking objectives to events, key events, and reporting dimensions.
- [] Traffic acquisition reports show the campaign and source information the team expects to see.
- [] UTM naming is standardized before campaign volume grows.

- [] Internal traffic or test traffic is handled intentionally rather than being mixed into performance reporting.
- [] Known data limitations are documented so a normal user does not mistake an estimate, delay, or modeling effect for a precise count.

8. Final audit sheet

Area	Status	What was verified	Open issue / owner
Property / stream			
Google tag			
Events			
Key events			
Ecommerce			
Testing			
Reporting			
Documentation			

What should be true before you trust the data?

- ☐ I can explain where the data comes from.
- ☐ I can reproduce the important events in a controlled test.
- ☐ I can tell which actions matter to the business and which are simply observed behavior.
- ☐ I know where the reporting may be incomplete or delayed.
- ☐ Another person could understand the measurement plan without reverse-engineering the site.

Reference note

Current Google documentation used for this checklist includes Google Analytics guidance on measurement IDs, recommended events, event parameters, key events, and custom campaign URL parameters. Verify the current Google interface before documenting exact click paths, because Analytics screens and labels can change.

Sources: support.google.com/analytics/answer/12270356 | support.google.com/analytics/answer/9267735 | support.google.com/analytics/answer/13675006 | support.google.com/analytics/answer/12844695 | support.google.com/analytics/answer/10917952